Received: 20 March 2019 | Revised: 18 June 2019 | Accepted: 20 July 2019

DOI: 10.1111/rsp3.12229

ORIGINAL ARTICLE

Cohesion Policy and European identity building: Trust as a mediating element

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Abstract

The understanding of the role of Cohesion Policy on the processes of European identity building is becoming more and more important in a period or resurgence of nationalisms and Euroscepticism. However, empirical evidence on this is still extremely scarce, due to both conceptual issues and data limitations. The present study tackles these limits and presents an empirical analysis of the way in which satisfaction with Cohesion Policy affected identification with Europe in EU regions between 2014 and 2017. Results show that this relationship is highly dependent on the intensity of funding spent, capturing the intensity of the European policy, and on the recent economic trend occurred at the regional level. This effect is boosted by a positive attitude towards EU institutions.

KEYWORDS
Cohesion Policy, trust in the EU, European identity

JEL CLASSIFICATION
E61; O10; R10

1 | INTRODUCTION

The study of the processes of European identity building is becoming more and more important in a period of economic and political crisis of the supranational institutions. While the competences and actions of the European Union became a pervasive element of citizens' life, covering a broad spectrum of policy fields, from the monetary policy to regional development, from agriculture to education and research, the future of a unified Europe is threatened by the resurgence of nationalist and Eurosceptic parties, culminated with the outcome of the referendum on Brexit. In

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such a scenario, the interest of both social scientists and policy-makers towards the relationship between EU policies and European identity largely increased.

This topic is relatively unexplored in the literature, with the most relevant exceptions concerning specific EU actions like the Erasmus programme (Van Mol, 2013) or the introduction of a common currency (Risse, 2003). The lack of evidence is mostly due to the fact that the main and explicit goal of EU policies is not the promotion of a common identity but, rather, the achievement of a variety of societal and economic objectives. Nevertheless, it can be assumed that the satisfaction of citizens with the actions of the EU translates, at least to a certain extent, into the identification with Europe as a whole, so that individuals consider themselves as members of a broader community than the local or national ones.

In other words, the idea that this paper wants to bring forward and to empirically test is that the satisfaction with the actions undertaken by the EU and, as a consequence, a higher level of trust in the EU institutions, is the element mediating the relationship between policy implementation and European identity. The goal of the present work is to study this mechanism, with a particular reference on Cohesion Policy.

Among all the kinds of EU funded policies, in fact, this mechanism is likely to apply in the case of EU regional policy. The reason for such a statement is that, on one hand, EU regional policies are highly diversified in order to address the needs of each region, implying that these actions are assumed to generate a positive and direct benefit on citizens' welfare. On the other hand, these policies have a high visibility, granted by the strict obligations that beneficiaries have to fulfil in terms of communication of the source of funding. Hence, the outcomes of the policies undertaken by the EU in their region become easily known by the citizenship.

The interest of this topic is testified by the launching of two research projects within the Horizon 2020 Framework Programme (López-Bazo & Royuela, 2017; Mendez & Bachtler, 2016),[1] with the aim of understanding the determinants of citizens' perception of Cohesion Policy implementation. Despite the advancements achieved by these two research programmes, still little is known about the link between EU policy perception and European identity. The goal of this paper is to shed light in this respect.

The structure of the paper is as follows. The next section discusses the relevant literature, pointing out the current limitations and the original contribution of the present study, clarifying how trust in EU institutions is expected to affect European identity. Section 3 presents the methodology and the data employed in the empirical analysis. Section 4 discusses the results, followed by conclusions and policy implications.

2 | EU POLICY IMPLEMENTATION AND EUROPEAN IDENTITY

Identity is one of the most transdisciplinary concepts in social science. From sociology (Burke, 1991), to political science (Bruter, 2003) to economics (Akerlof & Kranton, 2000), each discipline built its own theoretical framework providing specific definitions of identity and implications for the relevant domain.

In the context of the present study we adopt an economic perspective to identity. According to this framework, identification with a certain group or community implies that the individual cares about the relative status of the group and she/he wants to resemble to the members of the group (Shayo, 2009). In this sense, identification has a strong economic effect on individuals' behaviour and, in particular, on social interactions, stimulating cooperation within the same community. As pointed out by Capello (2018), when identity occurs, individual recognize that their private interests coincide with public ones, and they behave accordingly. In other words, pursuing one's own interest is not just increasing personal utility but, at the same time, creating a benefit for the whole group. This has extremely relevant economic consequences, because identity allows preventing free-riding behaviours, maximizing social welfare. Identity itself can therefore be considered as an economic asset of territories (Capello, 2019).

Transposed at the supranational level, citizens' identification with Europe is likely to promote cooperation and integration among countries, with the advantage of avoiding costs associated to barriers and obstacles of different

[1]The two projects are COHESIFY (www.cohesify.eu) and PERCEIVE (https://www.perceiveproject.eu/).

kind (Capello, Caragliu, & Fratesi, 2018). Hence, the implications of a weak common identity are not limited to the potential lack of support to the European institutions but, rather, they concern the possibility of missing the full advantage from social and economic integration.

The study of the determinants of European identity is therefore extremely important for the understanding of the socioeconomic processes of supranational integration. Within the literature focused on this issue, some works specifically addressed the contribution of EU policies to the processes of European identity building, in the aim of understanding whether the Communitarian actions produced any outcome on the citizens' feelings towards Europe.

Several of these studies considered the Erasmus programme, mainly for two reasons. First, this programme is explicitly aimed at improving the young generations' knowledge and understanding of the cultural similarities and peculiarities of EU countries, providing them with opportunities they would not have had in the absence of a supranational integration. Second, since the targeted population of the Erasmus is clearly identified (i.e., undergraduate students), empirical analyses are relatively easy to undertake through, for instance, survey studies on actual and potential beneficiaries. Despite the positive expectation of the Erasmus initiative on the European identity building, results are quite contrasting and highly dependent on both the country of origin of the beneficiaries and the methodological techniques adopted (Kuhn, 2012; Mitchell, 2015; Sigalas, 2010).

Even if it did not lead to conclusive findings, one of the merits of the abovementioned literature consists in having raised the issue about the relationship between EU policies and European identity. In fact, while the Erasmus programme is covering a relatively small share of the EU budget and it is focused on a specific category of potential beneficiaries, other policy frameworks have a more significant and generalized impact on citizens' life. As a consequence, they may be assumed to play an important role in shaping individuals' identification with Europe (Royuela & Lopez-Baso, 2019).

Compared with the Erasmus case, however, the empirical verification of this assumption presents several issues. First of all, economic and social EU policies do not generally have, as a primary scope, the formation of "European citizens" but, rather, the achievement of specific goals in various domains, from transport to finance, from ICT to agriculture. Second, the beneficiaries of these policies cannot be always unambiguously identified because, as for instance in the case of the provision of transport infrastructures, all EU citizens are potentially benefiting from the outcome of EU intervention.

In other words, in the case of generalist EU policies, it is not always possible to establish a direct link between involvement into the programme/policy and European identity. Instead, it is necessary to develop a conceptual framework devoted to the definition and identification of the elements that mediate the relationship between policy implementation and citizens' identification with Europe (Capello & Perucca, 2018).

Among the few examples of studies on the relationship between generalist EU policy implementation and European identity, Risse (2003) identified this mediating factor in the symbolic representation of EU policies. In his analysis on the introduction of a common currency, he pointed out that the creation of a material and tangible symbol of the monetary union had an effect on the citizens' feeling of being part of Europe, not anymore perceived just as an administrative and rather abstract construct.

The present paper argues that, apart from symbolic mechanisms, effective supranational policies make individuals satisfied with their outcomes and, as a consequence, with the EU institutions responsible for their implementation. This satisfaction, in turn, promotes trust in the EU institutions, as suggested by the several studies associating satisfaction with public policies with trust for the institutions responsible of their implementation (Bouckaert, Van de Walle, & Kampen, 2005; Welch, Hinnant, & Moon, 2004; Yang & Holzer, 2006). Hence, we assume that the same is valid also for EU actions: satisfied citizens are more likely to trust the institutions that undertook these actions. As argued by Verhaegen, Hooghe, and Quintelier (2017), in fact, political trust is based on the evaluation and performance of the political systems.

It is important, however, to define what is meant by trust in the context of this paper. As for identity, trust is also a concept whose effect on various forms of human wellbeing has been studied by several disciplines in the social sciences. In this study, it is defined in terms of *strategic* (Uslaner, 2008) or *cognition-based* trust (McAllister, 1995).

According to this perspective, individuals' trust depends on information and experience, and it is therefore generated by repeated interactions (Tsouri, 2019). With reference to the case discussed by the paper, the assumption is therefore that, once aware and satisfied with the outcomes of EU policies, citizens are likely to develop a sentiment of trust for the institutions responsible for these actions.[2]

Trust in EU institutions is assumed to influence the perception of supranational objectives as compatible with the individual and local ones. In other words, if citizens recognize that EU policies had a positive impact on their wellbeing, they will develop a higher level of trust for EU institutions which, in turn, is likely to make them identify with the European project and community. Given the definition of identity discussed above, this implies that individuals will be more likely to consider their own interest consistent with the supranational one.

The research hypothesis that this paper aims at testing concerns therefore the relationship between policy implementation, trust in the EU institutions and identification with Europe. Our assumption is that the level of trust in the EU plays a role on the effect of policy implementation on European identity.

Of course, such a mechanism is not assumed to occur for all kinds of EU policy. Since trust develops through information and experience, all those actions for which collecting information is either difficult or requires particular skills and knowledge, are less likely to promote trust and, in turn, reinforce a European identity. An example is represented by policies focused on the financial markets, or on international trade, whose functioning and outcomes are not easily perceivable for a large audience.

The case of Cohesion Policy is different, for several reasons. First of all, while citizens proved to have difficulties in developing a clear and unambiguous idea of what Cohesion Policy is and what actions are falling within this programme,[3] the authorities responsible for the implementation of the projects are committed to communicate their achievements, following official guidelines provided by the EU. These communication actions include, for instance, placards showing the EU flag, the details of the financial investments and the EU institutions responsible for funding. As a consequence, citizens experience a direct association between regional actions implemented with the Cohesion Policy programme and symbols of the EU, without having in many cases a precise understanding of the policy framework in which these actions were undertaken. Whenever citizens are satisfied with the outcome of these policies, however, we can assume them to improve their level of trust for the EU institutions responsible. Second, Cohesion Policy is conceived to solve specific regional needs and, therefore, it is directly aimed at increasing social welfare. Third, the magnitude of the investment is extremely relevant: funds allocated to Cohesion Policy correspond to almost one third of the EU total budget, 347.4 billion euro in the programming period 2007–2013. Fourth, despite the financing of the programme being the responsibility of the EU, the selection and management of policies is carried out at the regional level, thus allowing a higher level of participation of the local populations in the decision-making process.

Based on this reasoning, the present study focuses on the implementation of EU regional policy and on the analysis of the mechanism through which trust in the EU institutions mediates its effect on European identity.

In more detail, we expect the relationship to be influenced by two characteristics. The first one is the intensity of Cohesion Policy funding. As funding increases, the outcome of the programme is expected to be more relevant for local welfare and, as a consequence, trust for EU institutions is likely to become more and more important in explaining European identity. The second element is represented by the outcome of EU regional policy actions. Of course, such an element is not easily measurable, given the broad variety of projects and policies undertaken (Casi & Resmini, 2017). Nevertheless, the two main goals of Cohesion Policy are the achievement of convergence for lagging-behind regions and economic competitiveness for the others. As a consequence, we expect the relationship

[2]This definition of trust is consistent with an utilitarian approach to human behaviour, and it is conceptually opposed to the vision of trust as a moral value (Fukuyama, 1995).

[3]A recent survey study (European Commission, 2017a) showed that citizens' awareness of Cohesion Policy is highly dependent on the specific actions undertaken. For instance, 42% of respondents had already heard about the European Regional Development Fund, while this proportion is lower for both the Cohesion Fund (30.6%) and the Interreg Programme (14%). This poses an issue when trying to measure satisfaction with Cohesion Policy, since, given the complexity of EU administration (Pegan, 2017), the reference to this label can be highly misleading and confusing for the respondents.

between trust and European identity to be affected by the economic performance of the individuals' regions of residence. Obviously, the regional economic performance depends on a number of factors different from Cohesion Policy funding. However, if the regional economy of residence of the respondent is growing at a slower pace than the rest of the EU, we can assume that this will deteriorates her/his identification with Europe and, as a consequence, also the willingness of more integration. This is because the individual and local interest would be perceived as in conflict with the supranational one. Persistent poverty, economic decay and lack of opportunities have in fact been interpreted as the root of considerable discontent in declining and lagging-behind areas, leading to the present wave of political populism and Euroscepticism (Rodríguez-Pose, 2018).

The next section presents more in details the empirical model that will be tested, jointly with the data used and the methodological techniques applied.

3 | COHESION POLICY IMPLEMENTATION, TRUST IN THE EU AND EUROPEAN IDENTITY: DATA AND METHOD

The aim of the analysis is to study the relationship between individuals' European identity (our dependent variable) and Cohesion Policy implementation, shedding light on the mediating effect played by the level of trust in the EU. Empirically, the level of trust in the EU is defined by the citizens' perception of the EU Commission, the latter being the institution responsible for the management of EU regional policy and for most of the supranational programmes. The empirical model will therefore take the following form:

$$\begin{aligned} \textit{European identity}_i = {} & \alpha\,(\textit{trust in EU Commission})_i + \beta X_i + \theta\,(\textit{per capita funds})_r + \gamma\,(\textit{change in regional GDP from } t-3)_r \\ & + \tau\,(\textit{per capita GDP})_r + \lambda\,(\textit{year of EU accession})_c + \kappa_t + \varepsilon_i, \end{aligned} \tag{1}$$

where *i* stands for the individual, *r* for the NUTS 2 region of residence, *c* for the country of residence and *t* for the year. The main variable of interest for addressing the research hypotheses is the individual level of trust in the EU Commission. Then, two independent variables, defined at the regional level, capture respectively the intensity of Cohesion Policy funds (in *per capita* terms) invested in the previous year and the change in regional GDP occurred in the last three years.[4] The analysis will check whether the effect of trust in the EU Commission on European identity change at different levels of these regional variables. In order to isolate these effects, a number of additional controls are added to Equation (1). In the first place, a set of individual characteristics, such as gender, age, and education, are included. Second, two variables at the regional and country level measure respectively the level of GDP *per capita* and the year of accession to the EU. Finally, a set κ of time dummies captures any variation over time. A full list of regressors is provided in Table 1.

The data used for the empirical estimation of Equation (1) come from three Eurobarometer survey studies conducted in 2014, 2016 and 2017. Eurobarometer periodically conducts, on behalf of the EU Commission, survey analysis on a variety of topics of interest for EU policies. Among the recurrent topics of these studies, a specific question concerns European identity. More precisely, respondents are asked to declare how much attached they are to Europe. The answer can be chosen among four options, from "very attached" to "fairly attached" to "not very attached" to "not at all attached". In the recent years, several Eurobarometer waves included this question. In some of these issues, respondents were also asked to express their level of trust for the EU Commission.[5] The question wording is the following: "please tell me if you tend to trust or tend not to trust the EU Commission". The answer is dichotomous, namely, "tend to trust" vs "tend not to trust".

[4]The choice of a 3-year temporal lag is based on the assumption that, in a shorter period, divergence in regional GDP from the rest of the EU could be perceived as a temporary condition. On the other hand, a relative slowdown in the economic performance over three years mirrors a persistent pattern of divergence. Results using alternative definitions of the temporal lag (namely two-year and four-year) are consistent with those presented here and available from the authors upon request.

[5]These issues were conducted in 2014 (European Commission, 2014), 2016 (European Commission, 2016) and 2017a (European Commission, 2017b).

TABLE 1 List of variables included in Equation (1)

Variable name	Description	Source
Dependent variable		
European identity	Respondents' attachment to Europe: 1 (not at all attached, 10.71 per cent), 2 (not very attached, 27.74 per cent), 3 (fairly attached, 45.30 per cent), 4 (very attached, 16.25 per cent)	Eurobarometer
Independent variables: individual characteristics		
Trust in EU Commission	Dummy equal to 1 if the respondent trust the EU Commission (52.84 per cent of cases) and 0 otherwise (47.16 per cent)	Eurobarometer
Age	Age (in number of years) of the respondent	Eurobarometer
Gender	Dummy equal to 1 if the respondent is a female and equal to 0 otherwise	Eurobarometer
Occupation	Set of dummy variables for the occupation of the respondent: self-employed, manager, other white collar, manual worker, housekeeper, retired, student, unemployed	Eurobarometer
Marital status	Set of dummy variables for the marital status of the respondent: single, separated/divorced, widower	Eurobarometer
Independent variables: regional characteristics		
Per capita funds	Amount of *per capita* funds invested within Cohesion Policy programmes in the year before the interview	EU Commission
Change in GDP	Change of regional GDP in the last three years before the interview	Eurostat
Per capita GDP	*Per capita* GDP in the NUTS2 region of residence of the respondent	Eurostat
EU accession	Set of dummy variables for the year in which the country of residence of the respondent joined the EU	EU Commission
Year	Set of time dummies for the year during which the survey study was conducted	Eurobarometer

With reference to the Equation (1), the degree of European identity may take four values, from 1 ("not very attached") to 4 ("very attached"). The trust in the EU Commission, on the other hand, is a dummy variable taking the value of 1 if the individual tend to trust the institution and 0 otherwise.

Jointly with the abovementioned information, Eurobarometer survey studies collect information about some individual characteristics of the interviewees. This information includes gender, age, level of education, occupation, marital status and it is represented in Equation (1) by the matrix *X*.

Additionally, respondents are asked about their NUTS 2 region of residence. This allows including among the regressors some characteristics of the place where they live. In particular, given the focus of the analysis on Cohesion Policy, a first variable measures the *per capita* funding received by each region in the year before the interview. The source of these data is the EU Commission's database on historic payments.[6] The second variable takes into account the recent economic trend occurred in each region, defined by the change in GDP in the three years before the survey study.

Finally, the overall level of regional *per capita* GDP and the year of EU accession of the country of residence are added as further controls, since they may affect identification in Europe. Previous studies showed that individuals' income has a positive and significant effect on their identification with Europe (López-Bazo & Royuela, 2017). The survey studies employed in the present work do not provide data on the income of the respondents, and therefore the inclusion of the average *per capita* GDP on the region of residence is aimed at capturing this unobserved characteristic.[7] The inclusion of the year of accession of the country of residence to the EU is justified by the fact that the

[6]The database can be accessed here: https://cohesiondata.ec.europa.eu/Other/Historic-EU-payments-regionalised-and-modelled/tc55-7ysv

[7]It is worth mentioning that Equation (1) includes, at the individual level, indirect measures of individual income, such as education and occupation of the respondents.

length of membership plays a role in shaping citizens' affection and perception of Europe (Sanders, Bellucci, Tóka, & Torcal, 2012).[8] In a similar vein, since the literature pointed out differences in the identification with Europe between western and eastern Member States (Ceka & Sojka, 2016), Equation (1) is estimated for the whole sample but also separately for the two groups of countries.

Concerning the statistical techniques adopted, an issue in the structure of the data concerns the fact that individuals in the sample are nested within countries, at a first level, and within NUTS 2 regions at a second one. This hierarchical structure may imply that two randomly selected individuals from the same area are more similar, in terms of identification with Europe, than two people randomly chosen from other groups. If these group-effects are not taken into account, the independence assumption of the residual term ε_i from model (1) will not hold. While the most common solution to overcome this problem implies the inclusion in the estimated model a set of dummies for the groups (Frey & Stutzer, 2010). In our case, however, the high number of groups (i.e., NUTS 2 regions) makes this strategy not applicable. Therefore, we chose linear multilevel modelling to explicitly treat the hierarchical structure of the data and to correct standard errors. In more detail, similarly to the recent literature on survey data spatially clustered (Lenzi & Perucca, 2018), we estimate a random intercept model where the intercept of the group regression lines is allowed to randomly vary across areas.[9]

The next section presents and discusses the findings from the estimation of Equation (1).

4 | TRUST IN EU INSTITUTIONS, COHESION POLICY AND THE EFFECT ON EUROPEAN IDENTITY: EMPIRICAL RESULTS

The results of the empirical estimates are reported in Table 2. The first three columns of the Table show the regression output for the whole sample, including all EU countries.[10] In order to test potential multicollinearity issues among variables, the three group of regressors (see Table 1) are included separately. The first model (column (1)) includes only the trust in the EU Commission and the year of accession to the EU for the country of residence. In column (2) individual characteristics are added to the model specification. Finally, column (3) includes also the regressors defined at the regional level.

As expected, the association between trust in the EU Commission and European identity is positive and strongly significant, and the size of the coefficient is not affected by the inclusion of further controls. The year of accession of the country of residence to the EU does not matter in explaining the individual identification with Europe, especially after controlling for other relevant characteristics of the respondents. Among the latter, highly educated individual, students and those working in high-level professions show a higher attachment to Europe than the others. This finding mirrors the greater opportunities and benefits that European integration conveys for these categories of individuals. As discussed in the previous section, while information on personal income is not collected in the survey study, the inclusion of regional GDP has the expected positive sign, showing that an increase in regional domestic product is associated with a marginally diminishing increase in European identity.

On the other hand, neither the amount of *per capita* funds nor the change in regional GDP experienced in the three years before the survey have a positive impact on European identity. In other words, increasing the intensity of funding is not significantly related to an increase in the identification with Europe. Similarly, a better economic performance of the region of residence compared with the rest of Europe is not likely to affect individuals' attachment to Europe. Even if counterintuitive, the result on the intensity of funding is consistent with the evidence by Capello and Perucca (2019). Their study analysed individuals' satisfaction with Cohesion Policy as a function of

[8]Greece was the only country that joined the EU in 1981. In order to avoid collinearity considering accession in 1981 as a country-level fixed effect, the year of accession of Greece was considered together with Spain and Portugal, that joined the EU some time after, in 1986.

[9]Results are consistent with those obtained from alternative categorization of the dependent variable (i.e., (i.e., dichotomized in two classes, those who feel attached to Europe and those who do not) and statistical approaches (i.e., (i.e., multilevel models for categorical dependent variables instead of linear ones). Results are available from the authors upon request.

[10]Croatia is not included in the sample.

TABLE 2 European identity as a function of trust in the EU Commission: regression results

	Whole EU			Western EU countries			Eastern EU countries		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(1)	(2)	(3)	(1)	(2)	(3)
Trust in EU Commission	0.540*** (0.007)	0.503*** (0.007)	0.503*** (0.007)	0.540*** (0.008)	0.503*** (0.008)	0.502*** (0.008)	0.538*** (0.011)	0.503*** (0.011)	0.503*** (0.011)
Age		0.001*** (0.000)	0.001*** (0.000)		0.002*** (0.000)	0.002***		−0.000 (0.001)	−0.000 (0.001)
Gender (female)		−0.009 (0.007)	−0.009 (0.007)		0.009 (0.008)	0.009 (0.008)		−0.035*** (0.011)	−0.034*** (0.011)
Graduated		0.200*** (0.008)	0.200*** (0.008)		0.211*** (0.009)	0.210*** (0.009)		0.181*** (0.013)	0.181*** (0.013)
Self-employed		0.157*** (0.017)	0.157*** (0.017)		0.139*** (0.020)	0.138*** (0.020)		0.187*** (0.029)	0.189*** (0.029)
Manager		0.177*** (0.015)	0.176*** (0.015)		0.153*** (0.019)	0.152*** (0.019)		0.223*** (0.026)	0.225*** (0.026)
Other white collar		0.129*** (0.015)	0.129*** (0.015)		0.103*** (0.019)	0.102*** (0.019)		0.170*** (0.025)	0.172*** (0.025)
Manual worker		0.074*** (0.014)	0.073*** (0.014)		0.057*** (0.017)	0.056*** (0.017)		0.101*** (0.023)	0.103*** (0.023)
Housekeeper		0.038** (0.019)	0.038** (0.019)		−0.025 (0.023)	−0.025 (0.023)		0.135*** (0.032)	0.136*** (0.032)
Retired		0.103*** (0.015)	0.103*** (0.015)		0.097*** (0.019)	0.096*** (0.019)		0.109*** (0.026)	0.110*** (0.026)
Student		0.287*** (0.019)	0.287*** (0.019)		0.284*** (0.023)	0.283*** (0.023)		0.304*** (0.033)	0.305*** (0.033)
Single		0.002 (0.010)	0.002 (0.010)		−0.004 (0.011)	−0.004 (0.011)		0.011 (0.018)	0.011 (0.018)
Separated/Divorced		−0.023** (0.012)	−0.023** (0.012)		−0.042*** (0.015)	−0.042*** (0.015)		0.006 (0.019)	0.006 (0.019)
Widower		−0.118*** (0.012)	−0.118*** (0.012)		−0.138*** (0.016)	−0.138*** (0.016)		−0.078*** (0.019)	−0.078*** (0.019)

(Continues)

TABLE 2 (Continued)

	Whole EU			Western EU countries			Eastern EU countries		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(1)	(2)	(3)	(1)	(2)	(3)
Per capita funds			−0.056 (0.042)			−0.090 (0.067)			−0.107 (0.076)
Change in GDP (*t-3* to *t*)			−0.002 (0.060)			−0.055 (0.080)			−0.079 (0.111)
Per capita GDP (log)			0.118*** (0.042)			0.291*** (0.055)			−0.099 (0.062)
EU accession: 1973	−0.011 (0.107)	−0.030 (0.107)	−0.042 (0.104)	−0.011 (0.108)	−0.030 (0.103)	−0.058 (0.082)	-	-	-
EU accession: 1981/86	−0.180* (0.102)	−0.147 (0.102)	−0.061 (0.104)	−0.178* (0.102)	−0.139 (0.098)	0.062 (0.084)	-	-	-
EU accession: 1995	0.082 (0.103)	0.054 (0.104)	0.038 (0.101)	0.084 (0.104)	0.054 (0.100)	0.013 (0.079)	-	-	-
EU accession: 2004	−0.009 (0.083)	0.012 (0.083)	0.135 (0.090)	-	-	-	0.092 (0.123)	0.081 (0.131)	0.164 (0.134)
EU accession: 2007	−0.111 (0.119)	−0.077 (0.119)	0.128 (0.137)	-	-	-	-	-	-
Year 2016	0.090*** (0.008)	0.087*** (0.008)	0.073*** (0.009)	0.085*** (0.010)	0.081*** (0.010)	0.059*** (0.011)	0.099*** (0.013)	0.097*** (0.013)	0.085*** (0.018)
Year 2017	0.105*** (0.008)	0.101*** (0.008)	0.081*** (0.011)	0.111*** (0.010)	0.104*** (0.010)	0.077*** (0.012)	0.095*** (0.013)	0.096*** (0.013)	0.076*** (0.025)
Constant	2.374*** (0.060)	2.180*** (0.063)	2.594*** (0.184)	2.372*** (0.060)	.144*** (0.062)	3.208*** (0.244)	2.264*** (0.109)	2.139*** (0.120)	1.752*** (0.372)
Observations	62,789	62,789	62,789	38,641	38,641	38,641	24,148	24,148	24,148

Notes: Dependent variable: European identity proxied by the attachment to Europe. Standard errors in parentheses.
$^{***}p < 0.01$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{*}p < 0.1$.
Reference categories: unemployed (occupation), married (marital status), EU accession 1958 (year of accession to the EU), 2014 (year).

(among other things) the intensity of funding. Interestingly, the amount of *per capita* funds spent within the region of residence explained only the level of awareness of the population about the existence of an EU regional policy programme, but not the level of satisfaction. The latter, instead, was assumed to depend on some context conditions of the local policy settings and on the outcome of Cohesion Policy.

Based on this evidence, Table 2 shows the results of the estimates of Equation (1) on western and eastern EU Member States, analysed separately in order to test whether the different socio-economic environment, history and culture of the Eastern countries with respect to the Western ones play any role in the identification with Europe. In general, most results are similar. As far as the individual characteristics of the respondents are concerned, it is interesting to note that the sign and significance of the coefficients is fully comparable. In particular, the coefficient of the variable measuring trust in the EU Commission has the same size in the two group of countries. The only exceptions, associated to age, gender and the status of housekeeper, reflects differences in the social and occupational structures of the two groups of countries (Lange, 2008).

Concerning the regional variables, both *per capita* funds and regional GDP change have the same, insignificant association with European identity in western and eastern countries. A different result is instead obtained for overall *per capita* GDP. The last one has a positive relationship with identity only for old Member States, while the same does not apply for the new ones, where the average level of wealth is probably capturing also other regional characteristics, such as urbanization, being income highly polarized in large cities (Strano & Sood, 2016).

If, on average, neither *per capita* funds nor regional GDP change are associated with European identity, the scope of the analysis is to empirically test whether the opposite holds for their joint effect with the level of trust in the EU Commission. Rather than an interaction between the two variables, the joint effect will be investigated running a piecewise regression at different levels of the two regional variables. There are two justifications for this approach. First, conceptual considerations make us assume the interaction between trust and both funds and regional GDP change not to be linear. Second, it is interesting to understand whether, at different level of *per capita* funds and regional GDP change, the effect on European identity is associated either to trust or mistrust.

As far as the interaction between Cohesion Policy investments and trust in the EU Commission is concerned, we assume a positive joint effect. Based on what is discussed in Section 2, an increase in funding should imply a broader visibility of the outcomes of the EU actions, leading to a reinforcement of European identity, in a mechanism where policy implementation is mediated by a higher trust in EU institutions. Of course, this is expected to occur only when individuals are satisfied with the policy implemented. If it is not the case, namely, when individuals are not satisfied with the actions undertaken by the EU, they could even develop a sentiment of mistrust in the supranational institutions, leading to lower European identity.

The empirical results of the testing of this hypothesis are reported in Table 3 (model (4)) and graphically represented in Figure 1 (panel 1a). Empirical testing showed that, considering the whole EU, the gap in European identity between those who trust and do not trust the EU Commission is significantly increasing until the level of *per capita* funding corresponding to the 65th percentile. In other words, until the threshold of the 65th percentile of funding, a further increase in Cohesion Policy investments broadens the gap in European identity between those who trust and those who do not trust the EU Commission. Based on this, the equation estimated in Table 3 (model (4) uses this threshold to test for changes in the slope of the joint effect of trust and funding on European identity.

Results show that the broadening of the gap of European identity is not due, as assumed above, by a positive joint effect of trust and funding but, instead, by a negative joint effect of distrust and *per capita* investments. If we assume a link between satisfaction with EU policies and trust in EU institutions, these results imply that, until a certain percentile (i.e., the 65th), further increasing funding does not have a significant and positive effect of the European identity of satisfied individuals. Rather, it has a negative and significant effect on the identification with Europe of unsatisfied citizens. The implication in terms of policy is that making people satisfied with Cohesion Policy has a poor (positive) effect on European identity, while making people unsatisfied with these actions has a significant (negative) effect on their identification. This result is clearly visible in Figure 1a.

TABLE 3 Summary of piecewise regression for the joint effect on European identity of trust and *per capita* funds (model (4)) and trust and change in regional GDP (model(5))

	Model (4)			Model (5)		
	Whole EU	Western EU countries	Eastern EU countries	Whole EU	Western EU countries	Eastern EU countries
Trust in EU Commission (EUC)	0.489*** (0.010)	0.484*** (0.011)	0.511*** (0.027)	0.913*** (0.064)	0.924*** (0.066)	0.878*** (0.199)
Trust in EUC * Funds *per capita* (< 65th percentile)	0.133 (0.232)	0.797** (0.352)	−0.343 (0.407)			
No trust in EUC * Funds *per capita* (< 65th percentile)	−0.393* (0.233)	0.221 (0.334)	−0.619* (0.476)			
Trust in EUC * Funds *per capita* (>65th percentile)	−0.120** (0.054)	−0.061 (0.110)	−0.176** (0.083)			
No trust in EUC * Funds *per capita* (>65th percentile)	0.024 (0.057)	−0.185** (0.088)	0.048 (0.093)			
Trust in EUC × negative change in GDP				−1.000*** (0.289)	−1.344*** (0.323)	1.688** (0.847)
No trust in EUC × negative change in GDP				0.643*** (0.216)	0.258 (0.248)	3.398*** (0.702)
Trust in EUC × lower than EU average change in GDP				0.069 (0.227)	−0.156 (0.264)	0.319 (0.467)
No trust in EUC × lower than EU average change in GDP				0.627*** (0.219)	0.818*** (0.255)	0.203 (0.456)
Trust in EUC × higher than EU average change in GDP				0.028 (0.086)	0.028 (0.110)	−0.082 (0.156)
No trust in EUC × higher than EU average change in GDP				−0.311*** (0.096)	−0.273** (0.117)	−0.555*** (0.186)
Individual characteristics	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Other regional controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year dummy	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Constant	2.989***	3.722***	2.467***	3.399***	3.984***	1.893***
Observations	62,789	38,641	24,148	62,747	38,599	24,148

Notes: Standard errors in parentheses.
***$p < 0.01$, **$p < 0.05$, *$p < 0.1$.

Beyond the threshold of the 65th percentile, the gap starts shrinking in correspondence of further increases in Cohesion Policy expenditure, mainly due to the decrease in identification of those trusting the EU Commission. Even if this result confirms the initial assumption about a diminishing marginal return of funding on European identity, the negative association between trust and further increases of funding is unexpected and requires further investigation. One hypothesis for its justification concerns the very different mechanisms of European identity building of western and eastern Member States. Based on this reasoning the same piecewise regression analysis is repeated separately for the two blocks.

Results are reported in Table 3 and shown in Figure 1b (western countries) and Figure 1c (eastern countries). As far as western countries are concerned, findings demonstrate that, below the threshold of the 65th percentile, a further increase in funding is associated to an increase in European identity of trustful individuals, while it is neutral for

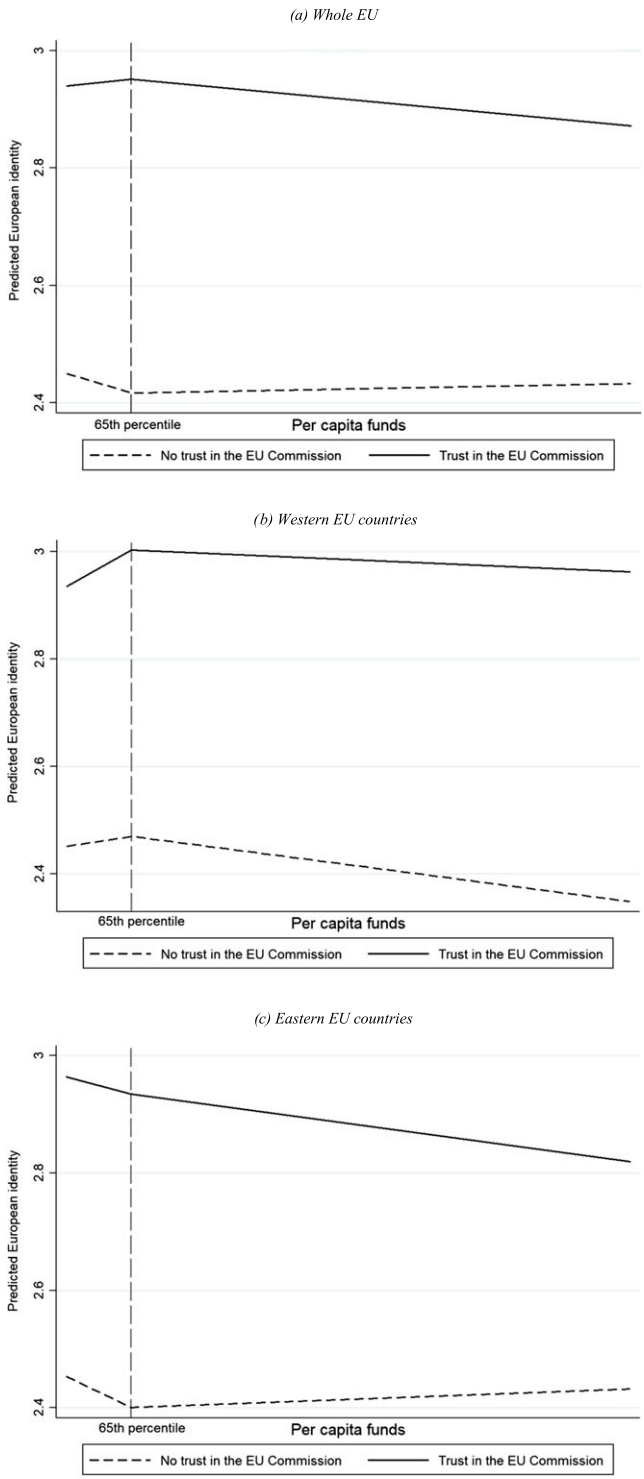
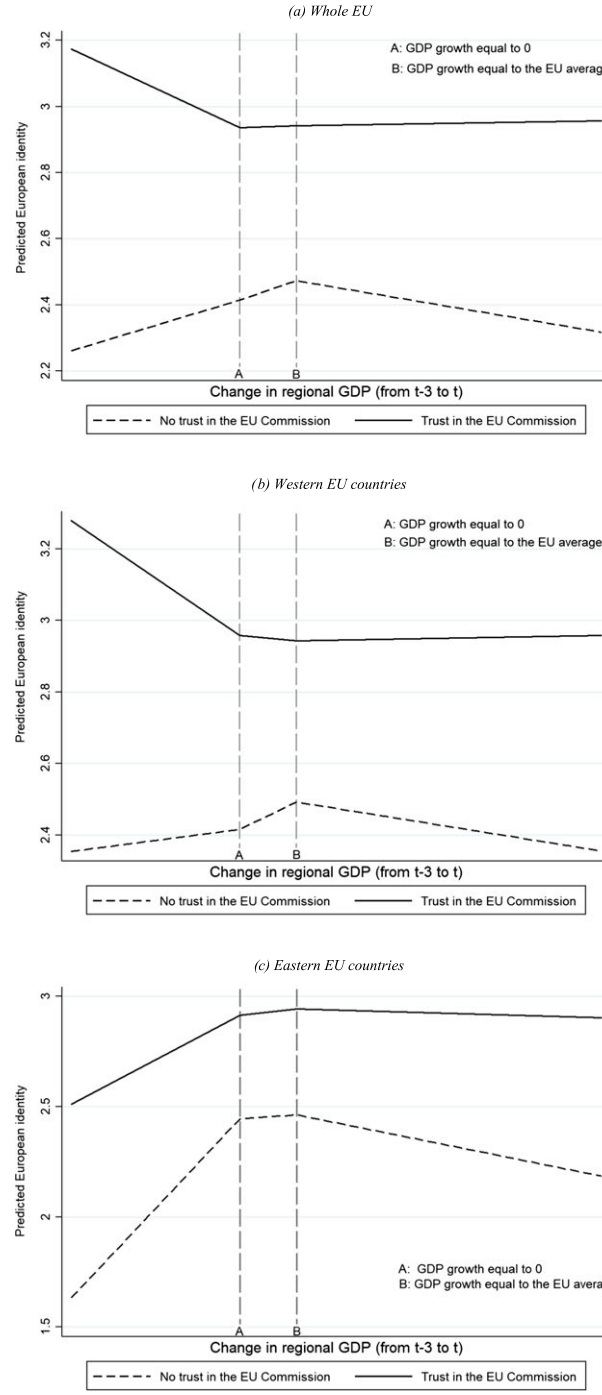


FIGURE 1 The joint effect of trust in the EU Commission and the intensity of funding on European identity

those who do not trust the EU. Above this threshold, on the other hand, the opposite holds: further investments do not change significantly the identification of trustful individuals, while they significantly decrease the level of European identity of those who do not trust the EU. This is fully consistent with our *ex ante* expectations: as funding

FIGURE 2 The joint effect of trust in the EU Commission and the three-year change in regional GDP on European identity



raises, EU actions are more visible and this makes individuals more likely to build a sentiment of trust in the EU institutions and, as an indirect consequence, to identify with Europe, even if this mechanism occurs with marginal diminishing rate.

In the case of eastern countries, instead, the relationship between trust, funding and European identity is rather different. Below the threshold of the 65th percentile, an increase in investments is associated to a

decrease in European identity for mistrustful individuals, consistently with the average effect for the whole EU and commented above. Above this threshold, such effect is negative for the trustful citizens, as in the unexpected result commented in Figure 1a. Therefore, for the highest levels of Cohesion Policy funding, trust in the EU Commission is less and less important in explaining the degree of identification with Europe. This result, holding only in the case of new Member States, could be related to other mechanisms of identity formation, typical of eastern countries, and less related than elsewhere to the policy intervention of the EU. As discussed in Section 2, in fact, our definition and economic approach to identity and trust is not exclusive. There may be other sources of identification with groups and institutions, related for instance to moral and cultural values that do not follow pure utilitarian mechanisms.

As far as the interaction between Cohesion Policy investments and the three-year change in regional GDP is considered, we assumed this relationship to vary for different kinds of scenarios. Compared with the previous case, where the significant threshold for *per capita* funding was determined empirically, in this case we conceptually identified three situations that may be associated to different mechanisms through which trust in the EU Commission contributes to European identity. The first situation is the one characterized by a negative regional GDP growth rate. In such scenario, economic issues are obviously at the centre of the public debate, and citizens are expected to worry about the performance of their regional economy. Citizens' perception of Cohesion Policy as an instrument for promoting economic prosperity in their region is therefore assumed to have a straightforward link to the trust in EU institutions and, indirectly, to the identification with Europe. As a consequence, trust in the EU Commission is expected to be a major determinant of European identity, and the gap between satisfied and unsatisfied citizens to be at its maximum in correspondence of poor performance of the regional economy.

The second scenario is characterized by a positive regional GDP growth, but still below the EU average. In this case we assume the mediating effect of trust on identity to be lower than in the previous case. Given the positive economic performance of the region, satisfaction and dissatisfaction probably contribute less than before to the individuals' perception of EU institutions. The same reasoning applies, even to a larger extent, to the third possible scenario, consisting of regions characterized by an economic performance higher than the EU average.[11] As in the previous situation, also in this case we expect the European identity of trustful respondents to increase as the change in GDP raises, but probably at a lower marginal rate, as suggested by the evidence referred to the overall level of wealth (Table 2).

These hypotheses are tested in Table 3 (model (5)) and Figure 2. As for *per capita* funding, a piecewise model was estimated, with two knots in correspondence of the levels of regional GDP growth in the three years before the survey equal respectively to zero and to the EU average change. As expected, in regions with negative GDP growth rates, the difference in European identity between trustful and mistrustful individuals is at the highest level. This gap is shrinking as the change in GDP progressively increases. For regions whose GDP growth rate is positive, a further increase in the economic performance is not associated with a reinforcement of the European identity of individuals trusting the EU Commission. Instead, mistrustful citizens identify themselves less and less in correspondence of the highest levels of GDP growth. Interestingly, the gap between the two groups broadens again for GDP growth rates higher than the EU average, even if it does not reach the same level verified in correspondence of the poorest regional economic performances.

Again, if we repeat the analysis separately for western and eastern EU countries, results are highly differentiated. While for western Member States, the evidence is consistent with what discussed for the whole EU (Figure 2b), the same does not hold for the EU 12 (Figure 2c). First, in regions with the poorest economic performance, the absolute level of European identity is significantly lower than in western countries for all individuals, whatever their level of

[11]Consistently with this assumption, we expect the share of population trusting the EU Commission to be an increasing function of the recent economic trend occurred in the region of residence. Empirical evidence from the Eurobarometer surveys employed in the present study supports this hypothesis. In regions characterized by an economic slowdown in three years before the survey, the share of respondents trusting the EU Commission is equal to 34%. The same share increases to 54.17% if we consider the regions with a positive but lower than the EU average GDP growth. Finally, in regions with a GDP growth rate higher than the EU average the share of trustful respondents is equal to 60.64%.

trust in EI institutions (see the intercept with the vertical axis in Figure 2c). Second, as the regional performance raises, the gap between those who trust the EU and those who do not shrinks, but the effect of a further increase in GDP is positive for both categories of people, even if with marginal decreasing returns.

5 | CONCLUSIONS

This paper analysed the relationship between European identification, trust in the EU Commission and Cohesion Policy implementation. In our approach, trust in the EU Commission mediates the effect of policy implementation on identity. Moreover, we assume trust to be directly influenced by the projects undertaken within the EU regional policy programme, since the latter actions are aimed at increasing social welfare. From this perspective, the analysis of this association is particularly important, because it contributes to shedding light on the role of Cohesion Policy in promoting European identity.

While, as expected, trust has a positive impact on identification with Europe, the most interesting findings concern the interaction of this variable with the intensity of funding and the recent economic performance of regions.

Increasing investments also increases the gap in European identity between trustful and mistrustful individuals, but at a diminishing marginal rate: above a certain threshold this mechanism is not verified anymore. This implies that the association between policy budget, trust in EU institutions and identity is not just a matter of intensity of the funding, but other factors mediate the European identity building processes.

Among these factors, the policy outcome is certainly relevant. As discussed in the previous sections, however, the outcome of Cohesion Policy is neither easy to assess nor unambiguously perceivable by citizens. Rather, individuals are more likely to be conscious of the overall economic trend of their regions, whose promotion is the very final goal of EU Regional Policy. Based on this reasoning, we included in our empirical model the regional GDP growth over the last three years. Its interaction with trust, and their joint effect on European identity, is highly diversified when considering different kinds of economic performance.

The most problematic case occurs when economic divergence takes place: in correspondence of the worst regional economic performances the gap in European identity between trustful and mistrustful citizens reaches its maximum level. These results is consistent with the interpretation of the recent consensus gained by populistic and Eurosceptic parties in many countries in Europe as the result of the downturn of the last ten years, and the consequent disaffection of citizens for the supranational institutions, rather than of wrong policy actions of the EU in the Cohesion Policy framework (Rodríguez-Pose, 2018).

The policy implications of the findings presented in the paper are relevant. While, of course, increasing satisfaction with Cohesion Policy is likely to promote trust in EU institutions and, in turn, an increase in European identity, these actions should be focused on specific local settings. These are, in the first place, lagging-behind regions, which experienced the lowest GDP growth rates of the EU in the recent past. Then, in western EU countries increasing satisfaction would be particularly effective, in terms of increasing European identity, for the major beneficiaries of funds. In eastern Member States, on the other hand, the same reasoning would apply to the most developed (i.e., receiving less funds) regions.

Finally, the mechanisms linking policy implementation, trust and European identity are still far from being fully understood. Future research should be aimed at shedding light on these processes, and also on the potential reverse causality mechanisms, where shared identities promote the reinforcement of trust.

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How to cite this article: Capello R, Perucca G. Cohesion Policy and European identity building: Trust as a mediating element. *Reg Sci Policy Pract*. 2019;11:637–653. https://doi.org/10.1111/rsp3.12229

DOI: 10.1111/rsp3.12229

Resumen. La comprensión del papel de la política de cohesión en los procesos de construcción de la identidad europea es cada vez más importante en un período de resurgimiento de los nacionalismos y el euroescepticismo. Sin embargo, las pruebas empíricas al respecto siguen siendo extremadamente escasas, debido tanto a cuestiones conceptuales como a las limitaciones de los datos. El presente estudio aborda estos límites y presenta un análisis empírico de la forma en que la satisfacción con la política de cohesión afectó a la identificación con Europa en las regiones de la UE entre 2014 y 2017. Los resultados muestran que esta relación depende en gran medida de la intensidad de la financiación que se gastó, la cual refleja la intensidad de la política europea, y también de la reciente tendencia económica que se ha producido a nivel regional. Este efecto se ve reforzado por una actitud positiva hacia las instituciones de la UE.

抄録: ヨーロッパ・アイデンティティの確立の過程における結束政策の役割を理解することは、ナショナリズムと欧州懐疑主義の再起の時代において、ますます重要になっている。しかし、概念上の問題とデータに限りがあるため、これに関する実証的エビデンスは、今なおほとんど得られていない。本稿ではこの限界に対処し、2014～2017 年の欧州連合（EU）の地域における、結束政策に対する満足のヨーロッパへの帰属意識に対する影響の与え方の実証的分析を行う。結果から、この関連性は、欧州の政策の強度を把握するのに使われた資金の集中度と、地域レベルの最近の経済動向に強く依存していることが示された。この作用は、EU の機関に対する肯定的な意識により促進される。

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